

Ἀριστόβουλος ὁ Ἰουδαῖος

Mosaic Law and Greek Philosophy in Aristobulus the Jewish Philosopher

eul_aid: lbi

Period: Ἑλληνιστική Hellenistic

Dialect: Κοινή Koine (phi, frg)

Domain: Φιλοσοφία Philosophy

Format: Πραγματεία Treatise

Affiliation: Peripatetic

Aristobulus was a Jewish philosopher who lived in the 2nd century BCE in Alexandria, Egypt, during the Hellenistic period. He is identified in historical sources as a Peripatetic, meaning he was part of the school of philosophy that followed Aristotle. His known work was dedicated to Ptolemy VI Philometor, a ruler of Egypt, which places his active career around the middle of that century.

He wrote a single major work, an Exposition of the Law of Moses, which survives only in fragments quoted by later Christian authors. In this treatise, he attempted a systematic harmonization of Jewish scripture with Greek philosophy. His central argument was that the wisdom of Greek philosophers like Aristotle and Plato was not original but was actually derived from the earlier teachings of Moses in the Hebrew Bible. To make this argument, he employed allegorical interpretation of scripture, a method that would become highly influential.

According to modern scholars, Aristobulus holds a pivotal place in intellectual history as one of the earliest Jewish thinkers to bridge Biblical tradition and Hellenistic philosophy. His work represents a significant early example of Jewish apologetic literature, which sought to demonstrate the compatibility and even superiority of Jewish thought within the Greek cultural world. His ideas directly influenced later Alexandrian Jewish thinkers, most notably Philo, and his fragments were preserved by early Christian writers who valued him as a pre-Christian witness to the philosophical depth of biblical teachings. He is thus seen as a crucial early link in a synthesis that would shape both later Jewish and early Christian intellectual history.

Works (1)

- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ τοῦ Μωσαϊκοῦ Νόμου · Exegetical Fragments on Mosaic Law · 12 passages

Other Peripatetic Authors

- Ἀγαθαρχίδης ὁ Κνίδιος · Agatharchides of Cnidus · 4 works
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἀφροδισιεύς · Alexander of Aphrodisias II · 2 works
- Ἀνδρόνικος ὁ Ῥόδιος · Andronicus of Rhodes · 2 works
- Ἀρίστων ὁ Κεῖος · Aristo of Ceos · 1 work
- Ἀριστοκλῆς ὁ Μεσσηνίος · Aristocles of Messene · 1 work

- Ἀριστόμβροτος ὁ φιλόσοφος · Aristombrotus the Philosopher · 1 work
- Ἀρίστων ὁ Κεῖος · Ariston of Ceos · 1 work
- Ἀσπάσιος ὁ Περιπατητικός · Aspasius the Peripatetic · 1 work
- Βοηθὸς ὁ Σιδώνιος · Boethus of Sidon · 1 work
- Χαμαιλέων ὁ Ἡρακλεώτης · Chamaeleon of Heraclea Pontica · 2 works
- Κλέαρχος ὁ Σολεύς · Clearchus of Soli · 1 work
- Κριτόλαος ὁ Φασηλίτης · Critolaus of Phaselis philosopher · 1 work